

Cross-Team Alignment and Model Sharing: How Teams Communicate Across Boundaries

Executive Summary

The hardest communication problem in organizations is not within teams — it is **between teams** that have different expertise, different terminology, and different mental models. Under Active Inference, cross-team communication requires building **shared representations** that bridge different generative models. This module examines inter-team communication protocols, boundary objects, alignment workshops, and the challenge of translating across specialist boundaries.

Learning Objectives

1. Identify **cross-team model misalignment** as a primary source of organizational dysfunction
 2. Understand **boundary objects** as shared representations that bridge specialist models
 3. Design **alignment workshops** that build shared understanding across teams
 4. Apply **liaison roles** and **boundary spanners** to improve cross-team model sharing
 5. Evaluate communication protocols for their effectiveness in model alignment
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Key Concepts

1. The Cross-Team Communication Problem

Each team develops its own generative model optimized for its domain — engineering thinks in technical specifications, marketing thinks in customer personas, finance thinks in P&L impact. Cross-team communication requires **translation** between these different model languages.

2. Boundary Objects (Star & Griesemer)

Boundary objects are artifacts that are shared across teams and have different meanings in each context, yet are recognizable enough to serve as a common reference:

- **Prototypes:** Physical or digital models that engineering, design, and marketing can all relate to
- **Customer journey maps:** Visual artifacts that connect marketing insights, product features, and support workflows
- **Dashboards:** Shared metrics views that different teams interpret through their own models
- **Roadmaps:** Timeline artifacts that coordinate planning across teams

Case Study — Boeing 777: Boeing's development of the 777 used a shared digital model (CATIA) as a boundary object connecting hundreds of engineering teams. Every team worked from the same 3D representation, enabling coordination that would have been impossible with traditional paper drawings.

3. Alignment Workshops

Structured sessions designed to build shared models across team boundaries:

- **Problem framing workshops:** Teams jointly define the problem from all perspectives
- **Assumption mapping:** Teams surface and compare their implicit beliefs
- **Model integration sessions:** Teams explicitly build a shared representation
- **Retrospectives:** Teams jointly learn from cross-team collaboration experiences

4. Boundary Spanners and Liaison Roles

Individuals who operate across team boundaries, carrying information and translating between different models:

- Product managers (bridge engineering and business)
- Account managers (bridge internal teams and customers)
- Integration architects (bridge technical teams)
- Agile coaches (bridge methodology and practice)

Cross-References

- For internal communication architecture, see [Organizational Systems: Communication](#)
 - For stakeholder narrative strategy, see [Strategic Modeling: Communication](#)
 - For API integration, see [Digital Transformation: Communication](#)
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Summary

Concept	Team/Collective Meaning
Cross-team misalignment	Different teams have different generative models that don't translate
Boundary objects	Shared artifacts that bridge specialist model differences
Alignment workshops	Structured sessions for building shared cross-team models
Boundary spanners	Individuals who translate across team boundaries
Communication protocols	Formal mechanisms for inter-team model sharing

References

- Star, S. L., & Griesemer, J. R. (1989). Institutional ecology, 'translations' and boundary objects. *Social Studies of Science*, 19(3), 387–420.
- Tushman, M. L., & Scanlan, T. J. (1981). Boundary spanning individuals. *Academy of Management Journal*, 24(2), 289–305.